We Have Beheld His Glory

A Study and Discussion Guide of Renaissance Sacred Art



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Introduction

The Word became flesh and dwelt among us, full of grace and truth; we have beheld His glory. (John 1:14)

That which was from the beginning, which we have heard, which we have seen with our eyes, which we have looked upon and touched with our hands, concerning the Word of Life—the life was made manifest, and we saw it, and testify to it. (1 John 1:1-2)

With these words, Saint John testifies to the mercy of God made manifest in the mystery of the Incarnation. The inspired author expresses a desire which proceeds from the very depths of the Divine Heart: God wants His children to see Him so that they might know Him, love Him, and "have fellowship" with Him. Since fallen human nature cannot behold God in His glory, God Himself took the initiative by assuming flesh and being born, not in majesty, but in the humility of the cave at Bethlehem.

Throughout the centuries, Christian artists have understood that their work is, in some way, a participation in the event of the Incarnation. By depicting the God-Man, His mysteries, or His saints, the artists offer the viewer a window through which to "see" and contemplate heavenly things.

All three artists referenced in this book were cognizant of their responsibility as cooperators with God and preachers of a visual Gospel. Although the three pieces reflect stylistic and cultural changes that occurred between the Late Medieval, Renaissance, and Baroque periods, each work invites the viewer to contemplate the same mystery: the Birth of Jesus Christ, the God-Man.

"We Have Beheld His Glory"
now includes a series of questions to assist in individual reflection
and family discussions with the art.



The continuity of subject is an important key for understanding Renaissance Humanism, which was not, contrary to modern misconceptions, a secular philosophy; rather, it was a deeply religious movement which looked with wonder at man because it recognized in him the image of the Creator. Man is free to choose between his spiritual, rational soul—and so nurture the seed of God's life within him—and his urge to unbridled pride and harmful desire.

Contemplation of the Incarnation brings this interior conflict into sharp relief, since by the Incarnation God elevated human nature to an even greater dignity by uniting it to Himself. From the poverty of the manger, God calls us to the sublime adventure of discipleship, but He will not coerce. Thus, in gazing at the Crèche, we are obliged to choose for ourselves: we can embrace our identity as a beloved son or daughter of God; or, in rebellion, we can reject the gift.

Through each artist's unique reflections on the Incarnation presented in the images below, the Christian is invited to hear God's call and to commit himself once again to this challenging but joy-filled path. He does so, however, with the certitude that God will not abandon him in the struggle.

The loving conversation between God and the soul that these three pieces inspire is the substance of prayer. May our encounter with the beauty of these works of art help us to lift our hearts and minds to the One who is Himself the source of all beauty, truth, goodness, and love.

Sacred Art from the Renaissance: The Adoration of the Shepherds

Three Italian artists explore the meaning of Christ's birth in works dating from before, during and shortly after the Renaissance. Art is a window into society, and through it all we see God's presence and influence. These artworks reflect societies very different from ours, yet their love of Our Savior unites us as it did hundreds of years ago.

1. *Adoration of the Shepherds (1311) by Giotto*
2. *Adoration of the Shepherds (1485) by Domenico Ghirlandaio*
3. *Adoration of the Shepherds (1642) by Guido Reni*









1. Adoration of the Shepherds (1311) by Giotto

Considered the grandfather of the Italian Renaissance, Giotto's artistic style had a major influence on the many artists who followed. Medieval artists rarely gave credit to their work because they understood themselves as vessels though which God was creating. In this case, however, we do know the name of the artist.

In this altarpiece, Mary's joy at the birth of her son is evident in her expression and body language. Above her, angels fill the sky, singing in praise of the Savior's birth. Golden light shines down from Heaven, falling on the newborn child. To the right, two shepherds react in shock as an angel appears to tell them the good news.

Below Mary, two women are bathing and swaddling the Christ Child. Joseph, sitting nearby, has recently fallen asleep.

At a time when giving birth was dangerous and infant mortality rates were high, the people of the Late Middle Ages would have identified with the precarious circumstances of Jesus' birth. Mary's experiences were deeply human, and her joys and sorrows were the same felt by all mankind. Here we see Mary celebrating her son's birth. Although she knows that her vocation as Mother of God will bring much sorrow and suffering, she is nevertheless filled with joy.

Reflect on the humanity of Jesus. Here we see Him being swaddled and bathed as a baby just like any other infant, however, we know He is much more than that. What does this depiction of Jesus' humanity mean to you? What other typical behaviors of childhood do you think He participated in?

The family that prays together stays together.



Giotto
Adoration of the Shepherds
1311
Florence, Italy



2. Adoration of the Shepherds (1485) by Domenico Ghirlandaio

This altarpiece is from the middle of the Renaissance when artistic style was about to experience a major change. Ghirlandaio's style of painting would soon become old-fashioned; he would be replaced by his own pupil, a young Michelangelo.

The Nativity is set in an Italian countryside, with ancient Roman ruins in place of a stable. This may be foreshadowing Christ's fate on the Cross, but it could also be a symbol of His triumph. Christ and His message have lasted the centuries while a once great empire is nothing more than old ruins.

Mary kneels before her son, her beautiful clothing a symbol of her grace and purity. In this artwork Mary is more formal, praying before the Christ-Child in adoration. She recognizes, in Him, her Son who is also her Savior and the Redeemer of the human race.

In the distance, the Three Magi and a parade of followers are coming down the road to join in the celebration. A small angel in the sky is leading them, and now it is Joseph who stares in amazement.

Finally, the shepherd pointing at Christ is a self-portrait of the artist. Ghirlandaio has included himself in a religious altarpiece, yet it is not out of vanity. Humanist philosophy of the time encouraged artists to identify themselves with their art, acknowledging the skill and talent which God had given them.

Reflect on the setting of Ghirlandaio's painting. What do you take away from the artist's choice of relocating the Nativity? How can we bring the joy of the Nativity into our own contemporary settings?



Domenico Ghirlandaio
Adoration of the Shepherds
1485
Florence, Italy



3. Adoration of the Shepherds (1642) by Guido Reni

Reni was a successful Baroque artist who created many biblical altarpieces that were displayed in churches throughout Italy.

The Baroque Period followed the Renaissance and was in large part a response to the Protestant Reformation happening in Europe at the time. While Humanism had a significant influence on the Reformation, it continued to exercise influence in Catholic thought.

This was a grand style specifically requested by the Church. The art is powerful and emotional, but also felt intimate. The shepherds crowd the manger, suggesting that the viewer is also among the crowd, trying to get a look at the newborn king.

The shepherds have brought their families with them, and in the crowd we see people of every age. This was a reminder that Jesus came to redeem everyone—young and old, rich, and poor alike. He appears to glow with heavenly light, a subtle reminder that He is both God and man.

Above the manger, in the sky, are cherubs celebrating the newborn King. Another common Baroque theme was movement. The cherubs appear momentarily frozen, and if you blink, they will return to their celebration. With emotional and familial biblical scenes like this, which sprang from Humanism, the Church hoped to counter the Protestant Reformation through image and beauty.

Take note of how Reni uses light in his painting. How does this reflect on Jesus as the Light of the World? Reflect and pray on Christ's light in your own life. Where do you see Him shining in your life?



Guido Reni
Adoration of the Shepherds
1642
Bologna, Italy

General Discussion Questions

1. Reflect on the first thing you notice about the painting. What drew you to this?

2. Note how Jesus is depicted in each painting. What do you think each artist is trying to say about Him? What thoughts and feelings does this image invoke in you?

3. When gazing upon the face of the Blessed Virgin Mary in each painting, what does the expression on her face demonstrate to us? What about her body language? What else do you notice about how she is portrayed?

4. Reflect on Saint Joseph. How can Joseph's different emotions reflect your own, especially with regards to the Nativity?

5. Pray with each of these images, journal and/or discuss whatever lessons or insights you are gleaming from these paintings.



Glossary

Renaissance
The Renaissance occurred from the 14th-17th centuries, beginning in Italy, and quickly spreading throughout Europe. International trade, as well as the European exploration of the Americas, led to a cultural 'melting pot' in Europe. A hallmark of this time period was Humanism, a movement inspired by Ancient Greek and Roman sources. The Catholic Church was involved in all facets of Renaissance life—including science, politics, and philosophy—and its influence in the arts was especially significant.

Altarpiece
A painting or sculpture that hung above and behind the altar of a church.

Humanism
Humanism was a literary and cultural movement which praised man's intellectual and creative capabilities. Intelligence and creativity were understood to be gifts from God, and therefore the best way to honor Him was to use those gifts to the full. God's interest in human affairs—to such an extent that He was willing to become one of us—is bound up with what it means to be human.

Baroque
The baroque art movement occurred in Italy from the 17th to the mid-18th century. It was characterized by drama, movement and grandeur. Religious art in particular was presented in a theatrical manner, as to invoke strong emotion. Scenes of Christ celebrated his time on earth, juxtaposing his Godliness with his humble origins. The Church greatly encouraged this art movement, as it was considered to be a rebuttal to the Protestant Reformation happening in Europe at the time.

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THE GIFT OF PRAYER

An Advent journey presented by Family Rosary

The family that prays together stays together.

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The Gift of Prayer

Advent is a time for prayerful, patient preparation and not simply a countdown to Christmas. Young kids eagerly mark the days until they receive their gifts while their parents count down the days until the (often crazy) holiday rush is over. But in truth, Advent is so much more than any of that. It is an expectant time of hope, peace, joy, and love. A time for us to prepare our hearts and homes for the coming of our Lord. It is a time to remember the most important gifts given to us by God—His Son as our Savior and the ability to connect with Him in prayer.

Prayer is one of the greatest gifts imaginable. Prayer is the Christian's anchor in tumultuous times. It is vital to building a relationship with our Lord. Venerable Patrick Peyton points out its significance, saying of prayer, "The friendship of God is the greatest gift a human being can get... and the greatest gift that you can give back to a God that gives you His friendship is adoration of that dear God." By praying to God, we adore Him in all His majesty through humbly coming before Him, and giving back all that we can.

The gift of prayer draws us into the life of the Trinity—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, and is the perfect preparation for Christmas. We pray you and your family rediscover the true treasures of the Advent season with the gift of prayer!

A Little History

Venerable Patrick Peyton began his ministry in 1942 with the goal of building family unity through daily prayer of the Rosary. Inspired by his own father who had a deep appreciation for family prayer, praying the Rosary became the foundation for the life of Father Peyton (1909-1992).

We at Family Rosary are ever so grateful Father Peyton's family instilled in him the importance of family prayer. Now it can be part of your family's tradition so you can fulfill Father Peyton's vision, "The Family That Prays Together Stays Together."

Family Rosary
HOLY CROSS
FAMILY MINISTRIES

The family that prays together stays together.

The Gift of Prayer

An Advent Journey presented by Family Rosary.

Our ministry team will be offering you and your family many resources to help you celebrate Advent and Christmas perhaps as you have never done before.

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Bringing Families Together In Prayer

We hope the time you've spent reflecting with this material has been enriching. Continue to pray with your family every day, wherever you are.

For additional online resources for family prayer including additional e-books and the mobile Rosary App, please visit our website at FamilyRosary.org.

This e-book and all our resources represent a culmination of Father Peyton's passion for family unity through prayer. We hope our services will enhance your family's prayer life particularly remembering Father Peyton's message, "The family that prays together stays together."

The family that prays together stays together.